Maria Muster

Doctoral-level researcher | Consulting · Process Design · Facilitation

CURRICULUM VITAE FOR A GERMAN START-UP GRANT APPLICATION

Name is a placeholder. Add personal contact details before submission.

Professional Profile and Planned Business

Planned independent practice: consulting, design and facilitation of participatory processes, and development of learning formats, serious games and research methodologies. Target clients include universities, research consortia, public institutions, NGOs and businesses.

The professional foundation combines a doctorate in governance and the socioeconomics of natural resources with international experience in research, consulting, project coordination and professional learning. Core strengths include collaboration across stakeholder groups, structured decision-making and translating research findings into practice.

Competencies Relevant to Self-Employment

- Consulting and client assignments: experience in international consulting mandates, feasibility studies, strategy development and methodological support.
- Project and programme management: coordination of multi-institutional initiatives, work packages, partner networks and training programmes; application of Agile methods and PRINCE2.
- Service delivery: design and facilitation of workshops, stakeholder dialogues, serious games, simulations and practice-oriented learning formats.
- Methodology development: participatory and transdisciplinary research, Living Labs, decision support and development of adaptable tools.

Professional Experience

Research Associate / Programme and Methodology Development

04/2023–03/2026 | Kassel Institute for Sustainability, University of Kassel · Cultures of Sustainability

- Designed and coordinated international workshops, learning programmes and multi-institutional collaboration.
- Developed and evaluated Living Lab methodologies, serious games and participatory formats; coordinated methodological integration across interdisciplinary teams.
- Developed transformation pathways, governance approaches and decision-support tools.

Consulting and Business Development, International consulting assignments · Sustainability, transformation and learning - 07/2021–03/2023

- Developed sustainability strategies, climate-resilience approaches and tools to strengthen organisational capacity.
- Designed interactive training, serious games and simulations; applied Agile and PRINCE2 approaches to project delivery.

Postdoctoral Research Associate, Bonn Alliance for Sustainability Research – Innovation Campus Bonn · 07/2019 -06/2021

- Led the Digitainable project: Bridged the science-society-policy gap at the intersection of sustainability and digitalization and developed a participatory assessment framework.
- Delivered stakeholder workshops, empirical research and capacity-development activities; supervised master's and doctoral research.

Senior Researcher, Project Coordinator and Lecturer, Institute for Technology and Resources Management, TH Köln - 02/2017–06/2019

- Coordinated international research and education partnerships, including the Nile Research Partnership and 2030AfricaWaterSecure.
- Developed blended-learning materials, organised events and delivered capacity development in governance and diplomacy.

Visiting Researcher, Eastern Nile Technical Regional Office (ENTRO), Addis Ababa, Ethiopia - 06/2015–11/2015

- Conducted field research and interviews on transboundary negotiations; facilitated stakeholder workshops and multi-party dialogue.

Earlier Experience

2012–2013 | Research Assistant, water-energy-food Nexus Research Project, ITT / TH Köln: supported capacity development for Nexus assessment models.

2011–2012 | Research Assistant / DAAD Programme Assistant, Faculty of Agriculture, University of Bonn.

2010–2011 | Research Assistant, Centre for Development Research (ZEF), University of Bonn: survey design, data collection and analysis, teaching and partner communication.

2005–2007 | Project Officer, River Training Project, Yekom Consulting Engineers, Tehran: developed approaches in water and renewable energy for private and public-sector clients.

Selected Consulting and Project Assignments

- 2025-Now | TransformERS (COST European Cooperation in Science & Technology) network Research-practice coordinator.
- 2025-2026 | MARGISTAR & Polytraps+ consortium - collaborative European research network.
- 2024-now |ITD Alliance - Global Alliance for Inter- and Transdisciplinarity : Toolkits and methods coordinator.
- 2025–2026 | ARSINOE / Horizon Europe: translated climate-risk and resilience data into actionable insights for start-ups and SMEs.
- 2024–2026 | SPARKLE / EU LIFE: co-developed local energy advisory structures for commercial building renovation.
- 2022 | NIRAS, Tanzania: feasibility study on resilience planning in East Africa.
- 2021–2022 | Global Council for Science and the Environment, USA: consulting on a knowledge-informed decision-making tool for conflict resolution.
- 2021 | Adelphi, Asia-Pacific: consulting on the Mekong Climate Change Adaptation Strategy and Action Plan.
- 2018–2022 | CNRD / Rockefeller Foundation: coordinated: Universities as Knowledge Brokers in the Governance of Climate Resilience.

Qualifications and Expertise

Higher Education

Doctorate (Dr. agr.) University of Bonn, Germany · 11/2012–01/2018

- Governance and socioeconomics of shared natural resources, with a focus on diplomacy.

Master of Science, University of Bonn, Germany · 04/2009–09/2012

- Agricultural Sciences & Sustainable Resource Management.

Bachelor of Science, University of Tehran, Iran · 1999–2003

- Agricultural Economics & Development.

Selected Professional Development

- 2026 | Awarded Short-Term Scientific Missions - COST European Cooperation in Science and Technology: Green Diplomacy in EU science-policy dialogue - Natural Resources Institute Finland (Luke).
- 2025 | ProProfessor, Mentoring Hessen: career development and preparation for a professorship.
- 2022 | New Horizons Worldwide Institute, Frankfurt: EXIN Agile SCRUM Foundation, Product Owner & Mastery.
- 2021 | Academy for International Cooperation, Bonn: behaviour change, social transformation and facilitation skills.
- 2021 | WINGS Professional Studies, UK: International Business Coaching and Strategic Management.
- 2015 | NADEL, ETH: evaluation of development cooperation and humanitarian projects.
- 2015 and 2016 | Harvard Law School & MIT: Water Diplomacy Workshop.

Methods, Tools and Languages

Methods: stakeholder engagement, co-creation, participatory research, serious games, simulations, blended learning, systems thinking and conflict resolution.

Tools and project approaches: Agile Scrum, PRINCE2, agent-based modelling, GIS, GAMS, SPSS/STATA and life-cycle assessment using SimaPro. The source CV does not separately document formal PRINCE2 certification.

Languages: Farsi – native; English – professional; German – intermediate; Arabic and Turkish – basic. No CEFR levels have been assigned without supporting evidence.

Selected Publications

Motlagh, M.; Horcea-Milcu, A. I.; König, B. (2025): Discovering the potential of serious games for transformative sustainability research. Discover Sustainability 6, 30. DOI: 10.1007/s43621-024-00756-8.

Gupta, S.; Motlagh, M.; Rhyner, J. (2020): The Digitalization Sustainability Matrix: A Participatory Research Tool for Investigating Digitainability. Sustainability. DOI: 10.3390/su12219283.

Under review:

Motlagh, M., & Augenstein, K. (Under review). Curating Game-Based Methods for Sustainability Education: Evaluating Student Perceptions and Transformative Learning Outcomes in Higher Education Courses. International Journal of Sustainability in Higher Education.

Sieber, I., Motlagh, M., Ritzmann, S., Horcea-Milcu, A.I., & Nahar, N. (Under review). Navigating the different dimensions of co-creation for sustainability research: Toward a shared understanding. Global Transitions.

Motlagh, M., Orduña Alegría, M., & Michalscheck, M. (Under review). Extending the Cycle: Leveraging Social Interaction and Co-learning in Sustainability Game-Based Learning. Frontiers in Education (section: Leadership in Education).

Horcea-Milcu, A.I., Sellnow, M., Bentz, J., Charli-Joseph, L., Moriggi, A., Motlagh, M., Bernert, P., & Cebrian, M. (Under review). The (re)generative uncertainty of transdisciplinary transformative research processes for sustainability: An exploration of toolkits. Sustainability Science.

Motlagh, M., Solano-Báez, M. C., & Sarkki, S. (Under review). Science-policy dialogue simulation game as a co-learning space: Empirical evidence within a green diplomacy framework. Environmental Science & Policy.